



Procedure

Policy and Guideline Review: Medications

Reference # MMP001

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
SCGOPHCG	Organisation Wide	All Staff

Introduction

This procedure outlines the governance process that the SCGOPHCG Drug and Therapeutics Committee (DTC) follows for reviewing and endorsing policy documents relating to medications.

DTC governed policy documents include:

- 1) Medication Management Policies – Contain standards, requirements and authorisations for the handling of medicines.
- 2) Medication Management Guidelines – contain information on the indication for use, dosing or administration of a medication
- 3) Medication Management Procedures – contain information on procedural aspects of the medication management cycle

In addition to DTC governed policy documents, any hospital policy, guideline, procedure or chart which references the use of medications must be endorsed by the Drug and Therapeutics Committee.

Risk Statement

Non-compliance with this procedure will:

Breach legislative requirements	☐	Impact on Patient Quality of Care	☒
Breach National/State/Hospital Policy	☒	Impact on Patient Safety	☒
Breach professional standards	☒	Misconduct	☐
Breach SCGOPHCG Mission & Values	☒	Staff Safety	☒
Other:	☐		

Definitions

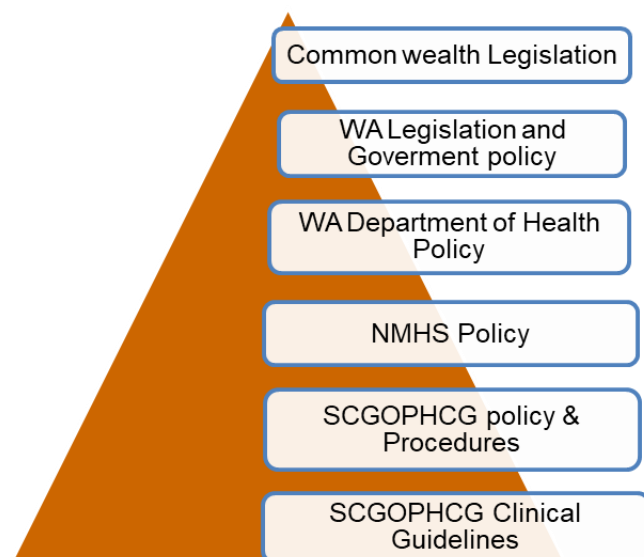
Guideline

A document which may support or link with a policy and describes statements, activities or steps which assist service providers and users of health services to make decisions about appropriate health care or service delivery for specific circumstances. Clinical guidelines use best available evidence to guide the care and management of patients/clients and assist

	a professional to make judgements and undertake actions in accordance with their skills, expertise and scope of practice allowing for flexibility in clinical decision making.
Policy	A document that describes the organisation's purpose or standard for a given customer process or issue, the expected outcome, guiding principles, roles and responsibilities, definitions of terms within the document and references. Compliance with policies is mandatory. A policy may be supported by a procedure or guideline.
Policy documents	A collective term used to describe policies, procedures and guidelines used within any area of NMHS.
Procedure	A document that generally supports a policy by describing a detailed set of instructions that clearly prescribes the action of each step of a process to be undertaken and by whom. Compliance with a procedure may be mandatory, as stipulated within the associated policy.
Executive Sponsor	The position that governs the development, review, revision, implementation, and evaluation of the policy document
Owner /Content Author	The position responsible for ensuring that all governance processes associated with development and implementation of the policy are actioned. The Owner may write the new or revised policy document or delegate responsibility to another person.

1.0 Overarching policies and guidelines

SCGOPHCG, policy documents must comply with legislative requirements and those policies of a higher level in the hierarchical structure. Where a higher-level document exists, staff will be referred to that document.



Staff must comply with the policy document development processes described in the following:

- [SCGOPHCG Policy and Guideline Document Development Process Flowchart](#)
- [NMHS Policy Document Development Guideline](#)
- [NMHS Policy Document Governance Policy](#)

See section 4.0 for further guidance on developing a medication management guideline or procedure.

2.0 Roles and responsibilities

Executive sponsor(s) are SCGOPHCG members that 'own' the policy document. They are responsible for:

- Accountability and responsibility of identified WA Health mandatory policy frameworks and requirements of those policies at a SCGOPHCG level.
- Overall accountability for the provision of accurate, contemporary and high-quality policy documents
- Ensuring requirements of WA Health mandatory policies are met
- Policy documents required by the business and workforce are in place (relevant to their portfolio area)
- Progressing development, review, management and maintaining contemporary knowledge about relevant policy documents.
- Ensuring adequate allocation of resources for policy development, management and governance

Document requestor / author are authors of policy documents who take responsibility for the policy research, drafting and consultation. They are responsible for:

- Undertaking research and drafting of new policy documents or updating existing documents
- Authorise and/or recommend rescindment of policy documents that are no longer required or valid
- Consultation with relevant stakeholders for development and/or review
- Completing the SCGOPHCG Policy Document Request Form
- Progression of draft documents through relevant governance committees and groups that require oversight
- Liaison with governing body regarding endorsement and quality assurance of the document
- Undertaking communication and implementation strategies post publication, in partnership with the relevant business area.

Drugs and Therapeutics Committee (DTC) are responsible for providing the overall governance of medication related documents at SCGOPHCG. They are responsible for:

- Ensuring review of medication related documents occurs within the appropriate review committee.
- Endorsement of medication related documents.
- Liaising with the PGC regarding review and approval for medication related documents.
- Maintaining oversight over medication management guidelines and procedures and escalating any documents overdue for review.
- Ensuring bi-monthly review and monitoring of percentage of documents with a current review due date.

Policy and Governance Committee (PGC) are responsible for providing administrative assistance with document library for medication relation documents. They are responsible for:

- Maintaining document library for medication related documents.

- Liaising with the DTC regarding review and approval for endorsement of medication related documents.
- Ensuring review notifications are distributed to authors, Executive sponsors and DTC EO within agreed upon timeframes.
- Publishing approved policy / guideline document on HealthPoint and/or removing any rescinded documents.
- Communicate policy / guideline updates via monthly bulletins and emails to Executive Committee, Policy Committee and Heads of Departments

3.0 Risk Rating

Policy reviews should occur as required with any organisation or practice changes or in relation to incidents.

Policy documents governed by the DTC are allocated a risk rating of either High, Medium or Low. All existing SCGOPHCG DTC governed documents will be reviewed at the interval determined by the risk rating:

Risk Rating	Review Date (does not negate continuous improvement and earlier document review)
Low	Review document in 5 years
Medium	Review document in 4 years
High	Review risk in 3 years

Refer to NMHS Risk Assessment Tables (adapted from the Risk Assessment Tables for the WA Health System) for guidance in calculating risk rating.

- This ensures allocation of risk rating is in line with guidance provided by WA Health and NMHS .

Risk ratings can further be determined based on clinical judgement, with consideration of the following factors:

- Medications included in the SCGOPHCG High Risk Medication Policy are generally considered high risk, and guidelines referenced within it are usually allocated a high risk rating.
 - Ratings are guided by the high risk medication acronym APINCH in combination with clinical judgement (e.g. all antibiotics are included in APINCH, however aminoglycosides are considered high risk and amoxycillin may not be)
- Consider if the information available in the guideline is available in another primary reference e.g. Therapeutic Guidelines or Australian Injectable Drug Handbook.
 - If the guideline does not provide additional information that is available in common reference texts then considerations of a lower risk rating may be appropriate.
- Clinical impact – choose a higher risk rating if an update to the guideline has been recommended in relation to an actual or near-miss clinical incident, or changes in clinical evidence or models of care.
- Usage frequency (Healthpoint data) – consider allocating a higher risk rating to documents which are frequently accessed

- Health impact on staff, health impact on patients or others, reputation, image and non compliance.
- Consequence assessment is undertaken considering the inherent risks.

Risk ratings are agreed upon by a group of subject matter experts including

- Drug and Therapeutics Committee Executive Officer
- Chief (Deputy) Pharmacist
- Pharmacy Department Team Leaders
- Medication Safety Pharmacist, Safety Quality & Performance
- Others as required

4.0 Policy document reviews

The purpose of a policy review is to take an in-depth look at existing policy documents to:

- determine whether a policy is still needed, if it should be consolidated with another policy, or rescinded
- determine whether the purpose of the policy document is still relevant
- determine whether the policy document requirements are relevant and achievable
- determine whether changes are required to improve the effectiveness or clarity of the policy document
- ensure that appropriate monitoring and ongoing maintenance of the policy document is occurring
- ensure that the context and reference material is still current and valid.

Reviews should be undertaken using a risk management approach. As such, SCGOPHCG DTC documents will have three forms of review:

- Formal Review (as specified per risk rating review)
- Proactive Review (as required).
- Desktop Quality Review (as required)

A **Formal Review** is to be undertaken within the relevant document review period (with relevant stakeholder engagement) unless an earlier review date is warranted, to ensure:

- policy document content is updated to reflect legislation, standards, best practice, clinical evidence, equipment and operational requirements
- ensure the document is contemporary, accurate, valid and required
- aligns to documents within the policy hierarchy including legislation and mandatory policy
- references, appendices and hyperlinks are accurate and functional
- policy template is the most current version and formatted appropriately in accordance with the NMHS Style Guide
- document summary and control information are updated and verified.

A formal review must always include all relevant stakeholders including all content matter experts that are affected by the document.

Proactive Review: There will be circumstances that warrant an earlier review, which may be instigated by the Executive Sponsor or any member of the document review panel. Proactive reviews may be undertaken in the following circumstances:

- Introduction or change in a higher-level policy document

- Introduction or change in legal or regulatory requirements feedback from staff that have raised/escalated concerns of inaccuracy, outdated or inappropriate policy documents
- Change in best practice or new evidence
- Safety issue and/or clinical incident or adverse event
- Requirements to consolidate policy documents

A proactive review must always include stakeholders to including all relevant content matter experts that are affected by the document.

Desktop Quality Review: A desktop quality review is an as required check of a policy document to ensure that the document:

- Is still valid, current and relevant
- Hyperlinks are operational and appropriate
- Is on the most recent policy template
- Summary information is accurate and valid.

These reviews may result in no change, or could prompt an update to the document, depending on the outcome of the review, including requiring a Formal Review. A Desktop Quality Review can only allow for the extension of the review date for 12 months. A Desktop Quality Review may include limited stakeholders where this can be facilitated.

5.0 Document development process

- Document development must follow the [SCGOPHCG Policy and Guideline Document Development Process Flowchart](#)

This section provides additional information for medication management guidelines and procedures that the Policy and Guideline Committee nominates the Drug and Therapeutics Committee to govern (Tier 2 committee).

5.1 Submission

- Document requestor / author to complete Section A-C of the [SCGOPHCG Policy Document Request Form](#) and send to the Policy and Audit Officer
 - PGC will refer to the DTC for governance of review/approval and endorsement.

5.2 Development

- Document requestor/author to draft the document using the SCGOPHCG Policy Document Template available on the [SCGOPHCG Policy Resources Healthpoint page](#)
- Document requestor /author to consult stakeholders nominated (as determined by DTC EO and document requestor / author – this is to include all relevant content matter experts that are affected by the document.
- Document requestor /author is to address stakeholders' comments, then complete Section D-F of the SCGOPHCG Policy Document Request

Form before sending it to the document sponsor and DTC EO with the draft document

5.3 Approval

- DTC EO to table the draft document at the most appropriate DTC subcommittee for content approval.
 - Most documents will be allocated to the Drug Evaluation Panel due to clinician-based membership representation.
 - Documents relating to antimicrobials may be allocated to the Antimicrobial Stewardship Committee (HAPI)
 - Documents relating to medication management or practices relevant to all medications (e.g. storage, prescribing, dispensing, disposal) may be allocated to the Medication Safety Committee
- If the draft policy document is approved, the document sponsor is to complete Section G of the SCGOPHCG Policy Document Request Form and send with the content-approved draft policy / guideline document to the DTC EO
- If draft policy / guideline document is rejected or requiring further review, DTC EO or relevant secretary from approval committee to communicate outcome and recommendations to document requestor / author

5.4 Endorsement

- The content-approved draft document and accompanying completed SCGOPHCG Policy Document Request form is tabled at DTC for endorsement
- DTC EO to notify document sponsor, requester/ author of outcomes

5.5 Communication

- Once endorsed, DTC will refer to PGC for ongoing administration:
 - Policy & Audit Officer to publish the endorsed policy / guideline document on HealthPoint or remove any rescinded
 - Policy & Audit Officer to communicate policy / guideline updates via monthly bulletins and emails to Executive Committee, Policy Committee and Heads of Departments

5.6 Implementation

- Document requestor / author and sponsor to implement the new policy / guideline document across relevant sites defined within the scope of the document

Compliance, monitoring and evaluation

- The DTC will be responsible for maintaining oversight over medication management guidelines and procedures and escalating any documents overdue for review.
 - This is to include: monthly review and monitoring of percentage of documents reviewed by the due date and subsequent review plan.

- To assist with ongoing monitoring, PGC will send review reminder emails by Policy & Audit Officer at least 6 months prior to the due date.
 - This is to include: Executive Sponsor, Author and DTC EO

Related Documents

- [SCGOPHCG Policy and Guideline Document Development Process](#)
- [NMHS Policy Document Development Guideline](#)
- [NMHS Policy Document Governance Policy](#)
- [WA Statewide Medicines Formulary Policy](#)

Authorisation & Version Control

Policy Sponsor	SCGHOPHCG Chief Pharmacist				
Policy Contact	Drug and Therapeutics Committee Executive Officer (Senior Pharmacist)				
Date First Issued:	01/10/2013	Last Reviewed:	15/08/2023	Review Date:	15/08/2028
Version No.	4	Reference #:			
Approved by:	SCGOPHCG Drugs and Therapeutics Committee			Date:	24/08/2023
Acknowledgments:	Alfred Health. Development and Approval of Policies and Guidelines. Corporate Governance, Alfred Health. 2009. Melbourne, VIC. Medication Safety Pharmacist SQP, Chief Pharmacist, Deputy Chief Pharmacist, Policy Officer				
Standards Applicable	Insert relevant NSQHS Standards (Version 2):  				
Aboriginal Health ISD Number:	n/a				

For full details regarding, development, review, consultation, approval, endorsement - contact the Policy Officer for the submission form

This document can be made available in alternative formats on request for a person with a disability.

SCGOPHCG Flowchart for DTC Governed Policy Documents

